Dutta's body was recovered next to Rajiv's, along with that of sixteen others, including the local superintendent of police Mohammed Iqbal and Congress workers who had come to catch a glimpse of their leader. The rest were lucky to have escaped the outcome of the blast. The Congress candidate from Sriperumbudur, Maragatham Chandrasekar, for whom Rajiv had gone to campaign, Tamil Nadu Congress Committee (TNCC) chief Vazhappady Ramamurthy, Congress general secretary G.K. Moopanar, prominent Congress politician Jayanthi Natarajan, Ramamurthy's PA and Arasu Nachiappan, a TNCC office-bearer, were in close proximity but managed to run away soon after the blast, fearing more explosions. Ramamurthy, Natarajan and Moopanar rushed back only to find Rajiv's mangled body at the site. Ramamurthy spotted Rajiv's Lotto shoe and screamed. Moopanar tried to lift Rajiv's body; his hands were smeared with blood and flesh and Rajiv lay motionless, with one-quarter of his skull missing.

*India Today*'s Madras bureau kept sending a blow-by-blow account of the post-assassination scene over the next twenty-four hours. For the first half an hour or so, total confusion reigned on the spot. By the time the police recovered their composure, the accomplices, if any, had ample time to hide either in metropolitan Madras or flee to the coast and then across the Palk Strait to the safety of Jaffna. Even the driver of the car in which Rajiv had arrived at the venue from the airport had fled the scene.

A former journalist who was then working in the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) informed Anirudhya that all states were being told to put their security forces on alert to pre-empt any backlash. The black memory of the time that followed Indira Gandhi's assassination was still vivid in the minds of many. Delhi was given special attention by the MHA and the army headquarters with the deployment of army columns. Security was beefed up in areas such as Karol Bagh, which had a sizeable Tamil population.

While the Madras bureau was sending ground reports, Anirudhya called a friend in Madras, Dr K. Chokalingam, a trauma surgeon and also the chairperson of the Congress party's medical cell. He was at the Madras General Hospital, where the post mortem had been conducted. Dr